

From metros to heartlands: WPL's growing reach signals bright future

WPL 2025 kicks off on **February 14**, with Gujarat Giants facing defending champion Royal Challengers Bengaluru at Vadodara's new Kotambi Stadium.

Shayan Acharya

shayan.acharya@thehindu.co.in

The Women's Premier League (WPL) may still be in its early days, but within just two years of its inception in 2023, it has managed to carve a significant niche for itself. This success has encouraged the Board of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI) to expand the tournament beyond the traditional metropolises. This season's biggest highlight is undoubtedly its geographical expansion. **Initially confined to Mumbai and later to Bengaluru and New Delhi in its second edition, the WPL has now added Vadodara and Lucknow to its roster.** This marks a step towards adopting a full-fledged home-and-away format.

The expansion is a substantial boost for the tournament, allowing the five teams and stakeholders to broaden their reach and tap into unexplored territories. While cities like Mumbai and Bengaluru have long had an established fan base for women's cricket, the impressive turnout at Vadodara's newly built Kotambi Stadium during India women's ODIs against West Indies last December convinced the BCCI to choose it as a venue. Lucknow, the home base for the UP Warriorz, has also previously hosted women's international matches.

Arun Dhumal, chairman of the IPL Governing Council, explained that the decision to expand was aimed at strengthening fan engagement in the franchises' respective home markets.

"Of the five franchises, three — Mumbai Indians, Delhi Capitals, and Royal Challengers Bengaluru — had already hosted matches at home in previous editions. So, we

wanted to create opportunities for the other two franchises — UP Warriorz and Gujarat Giants — to engage with their home audiences. That's why Vadodara and Lucknow were selected," Dhumal told *Sportstar*.

"Given the enormous fan engagement in Mumbai and Bengaluru, we decided to retain those venues as well. The tournament is still in its early stages, and the support it has garnered in these traditional cricket hubs is a tremendous boost for both the league and women's cricket," he added.

While Dhumal is confident about attracting strong turnouts at the two new venues, a post-tournament review will assess audience engagement. Based on this analysis, the feasibility of adopting a proper home-and-away format from next season will be considered.

"Logistics, available windows, and the best possible framework, all play a role in determining the next steps.

While the aim is to expand the tournament nationwide and build a sustainable fan base, these factors need to be balanced," Dhumal said.

In the league's first two editions,